

Stranded friend

If you received an e-mail from someone stranded abroad and asking for money, ignore it, as it most certainly is a scam

Job hunting?

Never pay up any sum of money to your potential employers, it is not standard practice



E-gold

The international currency used by hackers and scammers to trade information, as it is independent of inflation

Feature

Cybercafe Security

You never know what kind of malicious program or person is lurking in the next public computer you are going to use

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Cybercafes are not the safest place to surf. A number of users are bound to fill up the system with a whole bunch of viruses, worms and trojans, all of which can find their way into your portable devices. Some malicious programs can be used to relay personal information over the web. There may be keyloggers waiting to get into your accounts. Voyeuristic tendencies are not the only thing driving people to get access to your accounts, your e-mail account is one step away from your bank details and possible credit card numbers. Downloaded data, or data used for attachments can be abused by other people who come across it. A simple example: say user A downloads and prints a class project, and leaves the file there, user B comes along, and prints out the same project. There are a number of methods for gaining information, and using it maliciously. The techniques are many and varied, often changing from case to case. There are however, a few simple measures that users can take to ensure that they are not compromised while surfing at a cybercafé.

To start with, choose a cybercafé which is frequented by a lot of people. This ensures that there is a blizzard of data running through the computers, making your particular information less susceptible. Also choose a cybercafé which has enclosed cubicles. Make sure that your screen is not visible to passers-by, and your keyboard is

shielded from anyone looking over your shoulder. This gives you privacy. Also ensure that the cybercafé allows you to use USB drives. It is OK if USB drive has to be connected to a computer that the administrator of the café uses, which is a common constraint. This allows you to bring along your own set of tools to keep yourself safe.

The first step is to prepare a USB drive. Set up a few useful portable software in one of these, and you are ready to tackle most of the security issues that people

face at cybercafés. A portable version of Mozilla Firefox is the most stable portable browser around. There are portable builds of Opera too, if you prefer. Portable Firefox allows you to take your bookmarks and passwords with you, while not writing any information on the host computer.

This allows you to

bypass keyloggers as well. KeyPass is an Open Source application that stores all your passwords and allows you to login automatically. There is a portable version of KeyPass as well, which can be used in addition to portable Firefox.

Process Explorer is a small utility for monitoring system processes. It works off an exe file, without any installation. Process Explorer is a useful little tool to monitor, halt or pause any undesirable background activities on the host computer. It is also a good idea to carry a copy of Free Commander. Free Commander is a file explorer, that allows you to perform complex tasks and navigate the computer better. There is more on why this explorer is necessary later. Eraser is a great tool for



Specifying a strong master password

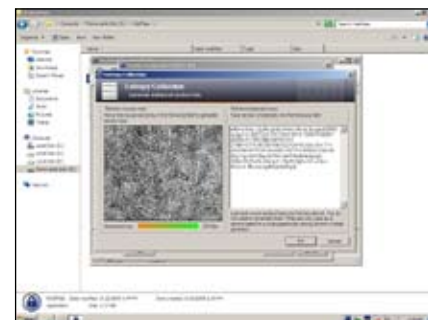
deleting data securely. All these programs run directly from the USB drive, and don't need administrator privileges. This set of applications can be used to avoid pitfalls, each of which are addressed individually.

Bypassing keyloggers

A keylogger can be any kind of mechanism to take a note of every key pressed by the user. There are a variety of keyloggers available, some of them are even open source! Keyloggers can be software-based, hardware-based, or both. A program that logs keystrokes is the most common kind of keylogger. Software based keyloggers can be remotely activated on a computer by a Trojan. This is usually accompanied by a time stamp. The keylogger does not itself know what is sensitive information and what is not. A typical log will look something like:

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9:04 http://www.google.comuser@gmail.compass
9:05 word1hello,Iwasintownandwonderingif
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Anyone going through the logsheet, can however sieve out the useful information. In this case, the username follows the url, and the password follows the username. Hardware based keyloggers, use a small chip in the keyboard, which is impossible to bypass. More sophisticated keyloggers can take periodic screenshots of the screen, track the mouse movements, log the keys and send all this information in real-time to a remote server. Some programs allow remote viewing of all activity on the host computer in real time. If you leave your computer unattended, they can even remotely control the mouse, and navigate to unsafe areas of say, your inbox. However, it is highly unlikely that anyone would go through the trouble to track the web activities of everyone in a cybercafé, because of the bandwidth involved. Sorting through all the data for anything useful is also a problem, but those with malicious intents have known to take the trouble. You should however, be mindful of specific and targeted attacks, where the probability of gaining sensitive information is higher. A cybercafé



Creating a random keyfile

A recently busted phishing scam in India involved a fake UTI website